



REVIEW UBUNTU 11.04 NATTY NARWHAL

The latest and greatest version of Ubuntu, 11.04 Natty Narwhal, was released on 28th April 2011. Ubuntu is now the most popular desktop operating system, and with this release, Canonical has made some major changes—both up front, and under the hood. Read on to learn more.

In Natty, Unity is the default desktop atop GNOME; it requires a 3D graphics accelerator, as it uses Compiz Fusion heavily—however, you can switch to GNOME Classic from the login menu, if you don't have the right hardware. Ubuntu 11.10 will be shipped with a 2D version of Unity, for systems with average graphics cards.

Natty replaces Ubuntu Netbook Edition for all PCs and netbooks. Available in the usual variants—Kubuntu (KDE), Xubuntu (XFCE), Edubuntu and more—the software defaults have also changed. LibreOffice 3.3.2 is now the default office suite; Firefox 4 is the default browser; and Banshee replaces the Rhythmbox music player.

The Ubiquity installer has 'graduated'

The Ubiquity installer is getting much smarter and understandable with every incremental release. People new to Linux (who fear messing up their existing OS while doing a dual-boot installation), and those who don't understand what swap space is, or how much they need of it, will like Ubiquity. This installer is quite impressive; it guides you at every step, letting you know what's happening, what you might want to do, and how it can be done. It detects whether you're installing on a system with an existing Windows installation, or upgrading from an earlier Ubuntu install, etc. It also has an expert partitioning option for experienced Linux

users. Once you enter the required choices, the installer begins copying files in the background, while you fill in additional information like the time zone, user details and more. The migration assistant, too, works flawlessly, and migrates your documents, pictures, user settings and so on without any hassle. You can also choose to install third-party software like Flash, MP3 codecs, Java, etc. Installation is not much speedier. Boot time from a live USB was less than a minute on a Core2Duo laptop, and two minutes on my netbook.

The Unity bar is here to stay

Like it or hate it, the Unity bar is clearly here to stay. It's had a major face-lift since 10.10, though it still sits atop GDE. It's not much different once you get past the layout and some basic controls. The new Unity interface is very innovative and neat, and saves screen real estate. It has a dock-style bar on the left with common applications, and a standard panel across the top. It auto-hides when you maximise windows, and comes back when you hover the mouse in the upper-right corner. The Unity bar scrolls icons when you hover the mouse pointer over the icons stacked like a deck of cards in the lower-right corner.

Click app icons to start them. A caret sign appears to the left of the icons for apps that are already running; a caret on the right of the icon shows the currently active app.